Himaayah Schools
ACADEMY

FREE GUIDE

إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْمُرُ بِالْعَدْلِ وَالْإِحْسَانِ

"Indeed, Allah commands justice and excellence." (an-Naḥl 16:90)

JAMB Government

A UTME study guide: concepts and thinkers, forms of government, Nigeria's constitutions and history, and a practice test.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Government in the UTME tests your understanding of political ideas, how governments are organised, and the history and institutions of Nigeria. Many questions are short definitions and dates, so a clear set of notes and regular past-question practice go a long way. This guide gives you the syllabus in five areas, the key concepts and dates, worked examples, the traps to avoid, an 8-week plan and a practice test.

The UTME at a glance	
Subjects	Use of English and three subjects for your course. Government is accepted or required for law, political science, public administration, international relations and many social science courses.
Questions	Use of English 60; each other subject 40; 180 questions in all, on computer (CBT).
Time	About two hours for all four papers, so roughly 40 seconds a question. You move freely between subjects.
Marking	Each subject is scored out of 100, for a total out of 400. There is no negative marking: never leave a question blank.

Check the official details

Exam rules and syllabuses can change from year to year. Always check the current JAMB brochure and the official Government syllabus on the JAMB website or e-facility portal, and follow them where they differ from this guide.

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Part 1 The syllabus at a glance

Study from the **JAMB syllabus**, not only from your school notes: every UTME question comes from a topic on it. The topics fall into these areas:

Area	Topics
Elements of government	Government as an institution, a process and an academic field; state, nation, power, authority, legitimacy, sovereignty; democracy, rule of law, separation of powers, checks and balances; political culture and socialisation; citizenship and rights
Forms of government	Unitary, federal and confederal systems; presidential and parliamentary systems; monarchy, oligarchy, aristocracy; capitalism, socialism, communism, fascism and feudalism
Organs and processes	Constitutions (written, unwritten, rigid, flexible); the legislature, executive and judiciary; political parties, pressure groups and public opinion; elections and electoral systems; the civil service and public corporations; local government
Nigerian government and politics	Pre-colonial systems (Hausa-Fulani, Yoruba, Igbo); colonial rule and indirect rule; constitutional development from 1922 to 1999; independence, the republics and military rule; federalism and state creation; INEC, local government reforms
Foreign policy and international organisations	Nigeria's foreign policy, with Africa as its centrepiece; ECOWAS, the OAU and AU, the UN, the Commonwealth and OPEC

Nigerian government and politics is the largest single area. Learn the constitutions and their features in a table, and the order of events from 1914 to 1999.

Part 2 Key concepts and dates

Concepts and thinkers

Concept	Meaning, and who is linked with it
Sovereignty	Supreme power of the state, with no higher authority within it (Jean Bodin; John Austin).
Legitimacy	The acceptance by the people of a government's right to rule.
Rule of law	Supremacy of the law, equality before the law and protection of rights (A. V. Dicey).
Separation of powers	Dividing government into legislature, executive and judiciary (Baron de Montesquieu).
Checks and balances	Each organ can limit the others, e.g. presidential veto, legislative override, judicial review.
Democracy	"Government of the people, by the people, for the people" (Abraham Lincoln).
Social contract	Government arises from an agreement among people (Thomas Hobbes, John Locke, Jean-Jacques Rousseau).
Federalism	Powers shared between a central government and component units by a written constitution (K. C. Wheare).

Nigeria's constitutional development

Constitution	Main features
Clifford Constitution, 1922	Introduced the elective principle (Lagos and Calabar); led to the first political parties.
Richards Constitution, 1946	Introduced regionalism: Northern, Western and Eastern Houses of Assembly.
Macpherson Constitution, 1951	Wider consultation; regional legislatures with more powers; a central Council of Ministers.
Lyttleton Constitution, 1954	Made Nigeria a federation; regional premiers.
Independence Constitution, 1960	Independence on 1 October 1960; parliamentary system; the Queen as head of state.
Republican Constitution, 1963	Nigeria became a republic; a ceremonial President (Nnamdi Azikiwe).
1979 Constitution	Introduced the presidential system (Second Republic).
1999 Constitution	The present constitution: presidential, federal, a bicameral National Assembly, 36 states and the FCT, 774 local government areas.

Dates and organisations

Event	Date
Amalgamation of Northern and Southern Protectorates (Lord Lugard)	1914

Independence	1 October 1960
First military coup	15 January 1966
Civil War	1967–1970
States created: 12 / 19 / 21 / 30 / 36	1967 / 1976 / 1987 / 1991 / 1996
Local government reform (uniform system)	1976
Return to civilian rule (Fourth Republic)	29 May 1999
OAU founded, Addis Ababa / replaced by the AU	1963 / 2002
ECOWAS founded (Treaty of Lagos)	1975
United Nations founded	1945
Nigeria joined OPEC	1971

Part 3 Sample questions, explained

Example 1. The principle that no one is above the law is known as:
→ Equality before the law is one of the pillars of the rule of law, as explained by A. V. Dicey.
Answer: The rule of law

Example 2. Which constitution introduced regionalism in Nigeria?
→ Regionalism, with the three regional Houses of Assembly, came with the Richards Constitution of 1946.
Answer: The Richards Constitution, 1946

Example 3. The power of courts to declare a law unconstitutional is called:
→ This is judicial review, a key check on the legislature and executive.
Answer: Judicial review

Example 4. A system in which the head of state and the head of government are the same person is:
→ In the presidential system, the President is both head of state and head of government.
Answer: The presidential system

Example 5. Indirect rule was most successful in Northern Nigeria because:
→ The emirate system already had a centralised authority, taxation and courts that the British used.
Answer: Of the existing centralised emirate system

Example 6. Proportional representation is an electoral system in which:
→ Seats are shared among parties according to their share of the votes.
Answer: Seats reflect each party's share of the votes

Example 7. The headquarters of ECOWAS is in:
→ ECOWAS was founded by the Treaty of Lagos in 1975; its Commission is based in Abuja.
Answer: Abuja

Example 8. A group that seeks to influence government policy without seeking power is a:
→ Pressure groups influence policy; political parties seek to form the government.
Answer: Pressure group

Example 9. The body that conducts federal elections in Nigeria is:
→ The Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC), established in 1998.
Answer: INEC

Part 4 Traps that cost marks

Trap	What to do
Mixing up the constitutions	Make a table: year, governor, main feature. Revise it every week.
Confusing pressure groups and parties	Parties seek power; pressure groups seek influence.
Mixing up thinkers	Montesquieu: separation of powers. Dicey: rule of law. Bodin and Austin: sovereignty. Lincoln: democracy.
Unitary versus federal	In a unitary state power is concentrated at the centre; in a federation it is shared by the constitution.
Dates of state creation	Learn 12, 19, 21, 30, 36 with their years.
Reading too fast	Watch for NOT and EXCEPT in the question.

Part 5 An 8-week plan

Start at least eight weeks before the exam. Each week: learn the topics, make short notes and solve past questions under time. Keep one day a week for revision.

Week	Focus	Practice
1	Basic concepts: state, power, authority, sovereignty	Definitions flashcards; 30 questions
2	Democracy, rule of law, separation of powers	Past questions; note thinkers
3	Forms of government and political ideologies	Comparison tables
4	Constitutions, organs of government, civil service	Past questions on each organ
5	Parties, pressure groups, elections, public opinion	30 questions a day
6	Pre-colonial and colonial Nigeria; constitutions 1922–1960	Constitution table
7	Post-independence Nigeria, federalism, foreign policy and organisations	Dates drill
8	Full revision and mock exams	Two full timed papers

Exam-day reminders

Read every option before choosing. Eliminate the clearly wrong ones first.

Do not spend more than a minute on one question: flag it and come back.

Answer every question; there is no penalty for a wrong answer.

Check that your answers are saved before you submit, and keep an eye on the clock for all four subjects.

Test Practice test

Give yourself 10 minutes for these 15 questions, as in the real exam. The answers follow.

1. **Who is associated with the theory of separation of powers?**
   a) Montesquieu b) Dicey c) Locke d) Marx

2. **Legitimacy means:**
   a) The use of force b) Acceptance of a government's right to rule c) Wealth of a state d) Size of the army

3. **Nigeria became a federation under the:**
   a) Clifford Constitution b) Richards Constitution c) Lyttleton Constitution d) 1979 Constitution

4. **Nigeria became a republic in:**
   a) 1960 b) 1966 c) 1979 d) 1963

5. **The presidential system was introduced in Nigeria by the:**
   a) 1960 Constitution b) 1963 Constitution c) 1979 Constitution d) 1946 Constitution

6. **The amalgamation of Northern and Southern Nigeria took place in:**
   a) 1900 b) 1914 c) 1922 d) 1960

7. **How many local government areas are recognised by the 1999 Constitution?**
   a) 774 b) 36 c) 589 d) 1,000

8. **ECOWAS was founded in:**
   a) 1963 b) 1960 c) 1975 d) 1999

9. **A constitution that is difficult to amend is described as:**
   a) Flexible b) Rigid c) Unwritten d) Unitary

10. **The upper house of Nigeria's National Assembly is the:**
    a) House of Representatives b) Federal Executive Council c) Council of State d) Senate

11. **Indirect rule in Nigeria is associated with:**
    a) Lord Lugard b) Hugh Clifford c) Arthur Richards d) John Macpherson

12. **"Government of the people, by the people, for the people" describes:**
    a) Monarchy b) Democracy c) Oligarchy d) Feudalism

13. **Which organ of government interprets the law?**
    a) The legislature b) The executive c) The judiciary d) The civil service

14. **The OAU was replaced by the African Union in:**
    a) 1999 b) 2002 c) 1975 d) 2010

15. **A state where power is concentrated in the central government is:**
    a) Unitary b) Federal c) Confederal d) Presidential

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	a) Montesquieu	9	b) Rigid
2	b) Acceptance of the right to rule	10	d) Senate
3	c) Lyttleton Constitution	11	a) Lord Lugard
4	d) 1963	12	b) Democracy
5	c) 1979 Constitution	13	c) The judiciary
6	b) 1914	14	b) 2002
7	a) 774	15	a) Unitary
8	c) 1975		

Recommended textbooks

- **Government for Senior Secondary Schools** (the government textbook your school uses), Books 1–3.
- The **1999 Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria** (as amended): read the chapters on fundamental objectives, rights and the organs of government.
- Other texts listed in the current JAMB Government syllabus.
- **Past questions**: solve at least the last ten years' UTME Government questions, timing yourself, and study every one you get wrong.

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وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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Concepts, constitutions and dates.

This free guide from the Himaayah Academy helps UTME candidates prepare for Government with clear notes on the ideas, institutions and history the exam asks about.

- The Government syllabus in five areas
- Key concepts and the thinkers behind them
- Nigeria’s constitutions from 1922 to 1999
- Dates and international organisations
- An 8-week plan and a 15-question practice test

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Live UTME classes with a personal mentor, daily tasks, weekly mock exams and CBT practice, all online.

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